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WORK, OPPORTUNITIES AND REINTEGRATION OF WOMEN INMATES AS FACTORS FOR PEACEBUILDING: A QUALITATIVE STUDY IN THREE MEXICAN PRISONS

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Abstract

Mexico is one of the 26 least peaceful countries in the world. From this perspective, examining peace from the context of the prison system makes sense, not only because cycles of violence are reproduced within and emerge from prisons but also because prisons are microcosms that reflect the absence of structural peace in the country. In this environment, women are doubly victimized, first, for their gender and, second, for their status as prisoners. This qualitative study explores the work of a civil society organization that seeks to contribute to the redignification, rehumanization and empowerment of women inmates in Mexico through inmate training, paid work and workshops. These topics have not been sufficiently studied in the context of Mexico and Latin America. Through 32 in-depth interviews and a series of observations conducted in three prisons in greater Mexico City, we explore inmates' perceptions regarding their circumstances and the programs in which they participate. The results indicate that these programs contribute to their emotional well-being, personal growth, sense of self-sufficiency, motivation and hope. They also help them feel that they are not being judged and that they are valued as women and human beings. Our findings lead us to conclude that programs such as these, if carefully implemented and sustained, have the potential not only to reduce violence but also to actively contribute to peacebuilding in specific locations through the strengthening of social cohesion, respect, human empowerment and gender.

Introduction

Mexico is not a country that lives in peace. Based on measurements taken over a period of several years, the Global Peace Index (Institute for Economics and Peace [IEP], 2018) continues to place this nation among the 25 least peaceful in the world. However, these circumstances are not limited to the conditions of violence in which the country has lived since approximately 2006 insofar as peace is not exclusively defined by the absence of war or violence (Galtung, 1985). In fact, while the negative aspect of peace is understood as the absence of violence or the absence of fearing violence, the positive aspects, or active components, of peace include the “attitudes, institutions and structures” that build and sustain peaceful societies (IEP, 2018). Therefore, a small but perhaps very important portion of this series of circumstances can be explored by studying how the prison system functions in a society. This can tell us something about what this society does to process the crimes or offenses committed that constitute a violation of the law and how it resolves the need to ensure that treating the crime does not feed into, or breed, violence. A society that takes positive peacebuilding seriously needs institutions that guarantee the upholding of the rule of law and mechanisms that ensure that impunity is low enough to not incentivize crime. However, at the same time, a society must find ways of ensuring that its prison system, through social readaptation and reintegration, actively contributes to building the pillars that generate and sustain peace. Otherwise, cycles of violence become intractable and never-ending.

This study does not attempt to explore all of these aspects; rather, it examines the very particular case of a civil society organization that strives to accomplish at least a small part of this task. Through this investigation, we hope to contribute to the body of knowledge on the subject, specifically focusing on what such action represents for peacebuilding in a country as Mexico. The Organization Studied offers paid work, in addition to other types of workshops, to a number of female inmates inside different prisons in the state of Mexico. The use of these types of programs by very different types of organizations in various countries is widespread. Nonetheless, our literature review found that, at least in Mexico, these types of programs are not sufficiently researched in a systematic way. In fact, we found a lack of qualitative inquiry into these types of initiatives throughout Latin America. Therefore, we considered it worthwhile to pose questions such as the following: How do program participants perceive these programs and their impact? Why is it important to learn about how program participants perceive these programs? How is the program participants’ perception socially constructed, and to what extent can it aid us in assessing the real potential impact of these programs? To what extent are these programs linked to gender issues, or do they result in new perceptions of gender empowerment on the part of the participants? What can this case teach other organizations and initiatives with similar objectives of promoting the common goals of building conditions for structural peace with a gender perspective in Mexico or in countries with similar conditions of violence?

Considering the above, the objective of this study is to explore how participants perceive the results of the programs and workshops through the systematization of the information gathered through 32 in-depth interviews (with 28 inmates and 4 ex-inmates) as well as direct observation in prisons and through the qualitative analysis of this information. At the same time, the study seeks to understand the strengths and potential areas of weakness of these workshops and programs. Thus, on the one hand, we offer fresh information for documenting the results of the work conducted by the Organization Studied and for making recommendations or contributing to the enrichment of

these very specific programs and workshops. On the other hand, for the academic and journalistic communities and the social and political sectors of the country, we offer a case study that documents the potential reach of workshops and programs such as those implemented by the Organization Studied so that such programs may be replicated or improved to contribute to building the conditions for structural peace in the country.

There is no overly academic way in which to affirm the following: what we found in our interviews, our observations and analysis of the information is that these programs transform the lives of their participants, when they are not factually saving them. Therefore, the elements we detect lead us to sustain the argument that these types of initiatives cannot be the exclusive duty of civil society organizations. Their implementation—or the launching of similar programs—should be deemed a macro endeavor of national public policy in countries that are absolutely serious about peacebuilding as a long-term project. This article attempts to explain why this is the case.

We start with the background and the conceptual framework. The methodology is then presented as well as the results. The findings are then discussed, explaining how these can be directly related to peacebuilding with a gender perspective. Some recommendations are offered at the end of the paper.

Background and Conceptual Framework

This study is based on different approaches. First, we aim to contribute a peacebuilding perspective to issues related to incarceration and the potential social reintegration of male and female inmates. This approach includes the incorporation of *noncomplementary behavior*, one of the conceptual tools that we will review. Second, we attempt to explain what gendered structural violence entails and how it is linked to the experiences of incarcerated Mexican women, with the aim of understanding this type of violence in relation to its counterpart, structural peace, from a gender perspective. Lastly, we will discuss some of the previous studies that are related to our study and that were conducted in different parts of the world, particularly in Mexico, to explain how our study contributes to the existing literature on the subject.

Prisons, Reintegration and Peacebuilding

This study's starting point is understanding that peace includes, but is not limited to, an absence of violence (Galtung, 1985; Alger, 1987). The negative aspect of peace—that which must not exist, in order for a society to be considered at peace—consists of the absence of violence and the absence of fear of violence. The positive aspect of peace includes those factors that actively generate or constitute it. These factors include all “attitudes, institutions and structures that sustain peaceful societies” (IEP, 2018). Thus, based on the study of the political, economic, social and cultural circumstances of dozens of countries that present high levels of peace throughout the last decades, different authors have explained the structural factors behind these countries' state of peace (Galtung, 1985). Condensing these concepts, the Institute for Economics and Peace describes eight indicators in which these societies, clearly and consistently, demonstrate better

performance than nonpeaceful societies. These are the eight pillars or backbones of positive peace: (1) a well-functioning government; (2) the equitable distribution of resources; (3) the free flow of information; (4) a sound business environment that is solid and conducive to businesses and companies; (5) high levels of human capital (generated through health, well-being, education, training, research and development); (6) acceptance of the rights of others; (7) low levels of corruption; and (8) good relations with neighbors, or what is better known as social cohesion (IEP, 2018).

From this perspective, it can be said that crime and violent crime are manifestations of the absence of peace in a society, which is not only due to the use of violence in the committing of such crimes. For example, studies throughout various decades and in very different countries consistently show that the greater the conditions of inequality are, the greater the number of violent crimes committed in a given context (Fajnzylber et al., 2002; Szalavitz, 2017). It is for this reason, among others, that the equitable distribution of resources becomes one of the pillars that sustains peaceful societies.

For the above reasons, a society that strives to build peace must address the building and/or solidification of each of the indicated pillars. On the other hand, it must ensure that when violent events, crimes or violations of the law occur, not only will there be retribution or consequences for such violations. It must also ensure that the factors prompting such violence will be transformed into positive actions that ensure respect, social cohesion and strengthening of human capital (which includes issues such as health or emotional well-being) and other active components of peace.

Social reintegration is more than an aspiration related to the prevention and reduction of crime or violent crime. It is a necessary condition for building peace from the roots up. This includes the fact that the reintegration efforts implemented from the time that inmates are incarcerated have the potential to reduce the tendency to commit crimes and display violent behavior, as has been shown in previous studies (Richmond, 2016). Furthermore, our study appears to indicate that the broader impact of social reintegration is a result of the design and implementation of adequate programs, which can potentially actively contribute to peacebuilding in different areas.

Noncomplementary Behavior: An Alternative?

According to Hopwood et al. (2013), complementarity is the most basic dynamic pattern in interpersonal theory. This pattern is generated when the interpersonal motives of each person coincide, and it reflects the baseline pattern for future relationships (Hopwood et al., 2013, pa. 28). This exchange is reflected in reciprocity, which can be expressed in two ways: (1) the vertical dimension (domination or submission relationships) and (2) the horizontal dimension (kindness attracts kindness, and remoteness attracts remoteness) (Hopwood et al., 2013, pa. 28). According to Hopwood, the normal course of action for a situation would be that one person behaving coldly towards another would lead to the other person being cold in return. This would cause the first person to become even more cold, and so on (Hopwood, 2016, pa. 10).

Along these lines, sensitivity to rejection (RS) is a function of cognitive affective processing that is perceived during interactions (Meehan et.al., 2018, p.119). Individuals with high RS anticipate rejection and other related responses (for example, hostile behaviors or social isolation). These reactions can lead to an even greater undermining of interpersonal relationships, generating greater

rejection in others and fostering a self-cycle of negative results (coldness, hostility). The RS studies focused on daily life have confirmed this pattern of reciprocity and correspondence that is naturally produced in social interactions (Meehan, et al., 2018 p. 109).

Hopwood (2016) suggests that noncomplementary behavior is linked to a change in the predicted behavior or response (pa. 15-17). In other words, a kind or caring response is offered in the face of a negative sign, communicative act or behavior. Despite the discomfort or risks to which this may lead on occasion, it can often result in a positive transformation of relations. The author explains that in psychotherapy, occasional high-impact noncomplementary moments can have a positive impact in the context of a trusting relationship (Hopwood, 2016, pa. 21-22). The question related to the present study is posed by Cisneros (2016) as follows: What guarantees that subjugation to the punishment of imprisonment will resolve the problem of violation of the law? This being the case, we ask ourselves what happens when, in response to criminal offenses or violation of the law, aside from imposing consequences and penalties, one offers paid work, opportunities, and a space that rehumanizes and redignifies those who have behaved antisocially. This study explores a case in which this is precisely what is done.

Gender Perspective

Gender theory is often overlooked in modern theories of peacebuilding (Confortini, 2006). For years, gender violence has been considered a subproduct of negative peace, while the importance of the construction of gender roles in the basic constitution of the absence of positive peace has been ignored. It generally remains unacknowledged that the existing structure in the gender sphere is not a consequence of violence but rather something that is intangibly implicated in historic and present reality. Interactions of power are critical factors for understanding the exercising of violence as a complex process in which social relations of gender and power are legitimized, constructed, replicated and established (Confortini, 2006).

From birth, women and men are taught to act relative to their biological sex. For this reason, the lives of numerous women and men have been restricted from the onset by their biological reality. In general, it is more difficult for women to access positions in the public sphere (Butler, 1999). Men, on the other hand, are taught to repress their feelings and act with certain virility and aggressiveness, which in some way operates as a limiting and aggravating factor of different types of violence because men are continuously obligated to prove their masculinity (Cacho, 2018). In the majority of contemporary societies, biological sex has been constructed and used to represent ideas regarding femininity and how a woman should behave (Lorber, 2010).

Therefore, gender issues cannot be limited to the “acceptance of the rights of others” as established in the pillars of peace (IEP, 2018). The incorporation of feminist theories and a gender perspective in peace studies is essential for understanding the structures that violate and harm the advancement of equality to successfully contribute to the building of different structures.

Prison and Gender in Mexico

Women who are confined in the Social Rehabilitation Center of Mexico's National Justice System [Centro de Rehabilitación Social del Sistema Nacional de Justicia de México] are allegedly

responsible for one or more crimes, whether due to an act or omission that violates the norms dictated by the Mexican legislative system (Azaola & Bergman, 2007b). According to the data of Mexico's National Institute of Statistics and Geography [Instituto Nacional de Estadística y Geografía de México - INEGI], there are 9,601 women incarcerated in state prisons and 1,121 in federal prisons (INEGI, 2017). In total, women represent 5.1% of the prison population, compared with the 217,000 incarcerated men (Franco Barrios, 2017). Most of the women currently in Mexican prisons are there due to crimes of violence, murder and drugs, followed by theft, kidnapping and extortion (Franco Barrios, 2017).

Prisons are responsible for reproducing a space of gender inequality (Azaola & Bergman, 2007a). Gender performativities (subjectivities) are widely visible in prison, and the effects of gendered structural violence are evident in the way in which women are treated (Naanous, 2018). In most cases, these women suffer oppression before they are incarcerated, and once they are in prison, they lack those elements that would enable them to rebuild a life away from crime (Salinas Boldo, 2014; Naanous, 2018).

In this sense, women continue to be assigned gender appropriate activities, including “domestic crafts, needlework and other kinds of domestic work that reinforce the social, economic and psychological dependence that put the majority of them in jail in the first place” (Hobson, 1990, p. 127). Although the programs of the Organization Studied here operate well and have managed to teach and empower women financially and psychologically, this organization continues to provide stereotypical activities for women. This type of situation can tend to accentuate the lack of a gender perspective found among the authorities (Naanous, 2018).

In Mexico, women are doubly victimized: first, due to their gender and, second, due to their status as prisoners. Thus, for women, punishment is experienced in both a real and symbolic way. Women within the system have been deemed the keepers of morality. Therefore, upon committing crimes, they break with this conception (Salinas Boldo, 2014). In fact, some studies suggest that judges tend to be much harder on female offenders than men because they are not seen as fulfilling the role of the “good woman” that is expected of them (Giacomello et al., 2018). Additionally, once they are released from prison, they must carry the extra stigma of having failed to meet society's expectations. This indicates the relevance of exploring the role played by the Organization Studied in terms of its contribution to the financial and psychological development of the female inmates aimed at preventing their recidivism (Naanous, 2018).

Studies Regarding Reintegration and Work in Prison

The psychosocial effects incurred in individuals who spend time in prison have been widely documented. For example, in a recent study conducted in Europe, Meijers et al. (2018) found that three months of incarceration in a negative or impoverished environment can cause decreased self-control, increased risk-taking behavior, and decreased attention span. The indirect consequences of this negative environment are chronic stress, lack of sleep, and aggressive behavior. This is relevant because when individuals are affected in this way, they are less able, even than before they entered prison, to lead their lives without breaking the law. Conversely, a successful return to society requires autonomous behavior directed towards goals and self-control. This study partially

explains why worse conditions in prisons can be related to higher indices of recidivism (Meijers et al., 2018, p. 4-5), which, naturally, from the perspective we have indicated, is directly linked to the difficulty of peacebuilding in a society.

Thus, “why work while incarcerated?” Richmond (2016) asks this in a study that consisted of interviews with 70 female and male inmates in prisons in Pennsylvania (pp. 236-238). The author tells us that there is sufficient evidence to corroborate that work in prison reduces bad behavior within the institution. It has also been shown that men who participate in work programs in prison are less likely to reoffend (Richmond, 2016). Interestingly, Richmond mentions that, according to his study, women do not consider money to be such a necessary part of their lives:

For the women, simply being employed while incarcerated is not significant. The additional money that inmates can make in prison industries is important to the men and allows them to feel independent. Money did not seem to be as pressing of a concern to the women. While it allows them to purchase items such as food and toiletries from the commissary, their need for money is not as strong. This may be due to the fact that women are receiving support from families on the outside (p. 244).

This last finding was one of the topics explored in-depth in our interviews, first, because the economic and family conditions in Mexico are extremely different from the conditions in a country such as the United States and, second, due to the particular type of programs implemented by the Organization Studied. What Richmond does determine is that the programs explored by his study improve women and men's self-perception (the feeling of no longer being in prison, trusting in themselves, a sense of accomplishment). Richmond's study also showed that these programs function as incentives for staying out of trouble and developing one's interpersonal skills (the desire to maintain their job motivated inmates to overcome obstacles; they learned to work with people from diverse contexts and with different personalities, generate a community and move away from the “criminal mentality”). In conclusion, it is suggested that work in prisons provides inmates with structure and purpose, develops self-esteem, and generates positive social ties (Richmond, 2016).

For their part, Uggen & Staff (2001) conduct a broad literature review regarding the impact of employment on ex-convicts. This review leads the authors to conclude that work, particularly in the case of older ex-convicts, as well as criminals with addictions, can effectively bring about a “turning point” towards a conventional lifestyle and that it is also effective in reducing crime and recidivism (p. 14). Other studies, such as that of Gaes (2008), review existing evidence regarding the impact of educational programs in prisons based on post-liberation results (p. 1). The conclusion is that correctional education reduces recidivism and increases the possibility of employment (Gaes, 2008, p. 11).

In short, the evidence gathered in different parts of the world appears to indicate that work and educational programs for prison inmates have positive effects in terms of reductions of crime and violence and could therefore contribute to peacebuilding in a society.

The Case of Mexico

Villa y Caña (2017) indicate that social reintegration does not work in Mexico, which is reflected by the high indices of repetition of offenses. These indices are 60%, according to the Decentralized Body of Prevention and Social Reintegration [Órgano Desconcentrado de Prevención y de Reinserción Social] (Villa y Caña, 2017, p. 1). The authors remind us that Article 18 of the Mexican constitution establishes that reintegration should be achieved through work training or other related activities. Nonetheless, historically, this does not effectively occur (Villa y Caña 2017, pa. 3-5). These findings are corroborated by Córdova (2016), who, based on a qualitative study that uses in-depth interviews with inmates and personnel in two prisons in Mexico City, concludes that the function of social reintegration exceeds the institutional scope of these prisons. This calls into question the existing system's efficacy in achieving social readaptation in Mexican prisons. Similarly, through a study that uses the workshop as a research tool, employing dialogue and coexistence with women in Mexican prison centers, Leal et al. (2015) explain that despite the fact that prisons are established with a discourse of social and labor reintegration, they do everything but prepare convicts for a life outside of prison. The authors indicate that, by contrast, the resistance expressed in the workshops that they explored might serve as beneficial practices for reintegration, which contrasts with the institutional practices of punishment, control, isolation and mortification of the individual (p. 118). That is, according to the authors, the inmates use the workshops as mechanisms of resistance through the resignifying of such practices. In their words: "The product proposed for reintegrating the subject (i.e., the workshops) is readjusted: it is consumed more for the purpose of forgetting and expressing oneself than for learning certain social skills aimed at individual correction or reflection" (p. 131).

With regard to our literature review, it is worth mentioning that Rosales, Ortiz and Limas (2005) noted that the research regarding the perceptions of female inmates in Mexico is extremely scarce. Rosales et al., conducted a study based on interviews, mainly using questionnaires applied to women inmates regarding their perceptions of certain reintegration programs. These programs include schooling, work training and employment in certain workshops (Rosales et al., 2005). The most relevant conceptual aspect that the study contributed for the purposes of our study is that of feminine subjectivity given that, as explained above, due to matters of gender, the structural causes that drive women to commit crimes differ from those that cause men to commit crimes to a certain degree (Rosales et al., 2005). However, there are aspects of feminine identity that affect the process of readaptation such as maternity, feminine corporality and even the way in which women experience their religious beliefs. Nonetheless, the author reports that the programs that she studied do not appear to benefit the inmates (Rosales et al., 2005, p. 21). In this sense, we deemed it important to explore other types of programs, such as those implemented by the Organization Studied, and to explore in greater depth what has been revealed by the existing studies.

In a more recent study, Córdova concurs that the academic research on the subject of employment and social reintegration in Mexican prisons is scarce, and therefore, in her study, she uses for inspiration models from other geographic locations, the realities and contexts of which differ from the Mexican context (Córdova, 2016).

We found sound quantitative studies such as that carried out by Estrada et al. (2014), who sought to define the profile of formal and informal support networks in relation to the social reintegration of users of the program of the Directorate of the Post-Penitentiary System and Care for Released Prisoners of the State of Jalisco, Mexico [Dirección del Sistema Postpenitenciario y Atención a Liberados del Estado de Jalisco, México]. Similarly, we found few qualitative studies regarding this topic in Mexico. One such study was an undergraduate thesis consisting of an observational, cross-sectional and descriptive study of 35 inmates of the Correctional Center of Social Readaptation of Ecatepec [Centro Penitenciario de Readaptación Social de Ecatepec] who participated in vocational workshops (Gonzalez Plata 2013). Gonzalez Plata concluded that due to the average level of motivation, the workshops affected the inmates in a favorable way (i.e., decreasing anxiety and the lack of future prospects). For their part, León & Roldán (2007) conducted a qualitative study in the Tepepan Women's Center for Social Readaptation (Mexico City) [Centro Femenil de Readaptación Social Tepepan (CDMX)], which consisted of consulting technical files and conducting in-depth interviews to explore the participants' feelings and perspectives relative to the underlying causes of their situations and the circumstances leading up to their offense. The study also explored how the participants perceived their work in prison. The majority of the participants expressed that it did not make sense to work in the institution (cooking and cleaning) because the amount of money that they earned was not enough to cover their expenses and provide for their families. It is interesting to note that the majority of the women thought that the work was useless insofar as they ended up working in the same way that they did in their homes (the majority of the inmates were housewives). In other words, this type of work reinforces women's domesticity (Gonzalez Plata, 2013, p. 100), which is one of the issues reviewed above and explored in the present study.

Our study draws from this literature, which served both to develop our interview protocol and to develop the categories of analysis that we used. However, given the lack of in-depth qualitative evidence regarding paid work inside women's prisons in Mexico, and in Latin America in general, our investigation seeks to contribute to the existing literature, especially from a peacebuilding point of view with a gender perspective.

The Organization Studied

The Organization Studied is a civil society group formed in 2011 by young women who were students at the time: three lawyers and one psychologist. They began by taking recreational activities to prisons, such as games and movies, as well as presentations and celebrations such as *posadas* (traditional celebrations in Mexico). However, the young women soon realized that these activities did not have a relevant impact on inmates. Therefore, they decided to bring knitting classes to the prisons with the aim of providing inmates with a trade.

One of the organization's founders describes her association as a group that seeks to “create opportunities of a different life goal for women deprived of their freedom through training and access to dignified and quality employment, through which they can satisfy their basic needs, support their families and occupy their time in prison with constructive activities” (Organization founder, personal communication, January 15, 2019).

Once the employees of this organization enter into contact with the inmates and build enough trust with them, they present them with a program of comprehensive social reintegration so that, in addition to paid work, they might have access to complementary activities that strengthen their process in different areas such as psychological care, art, culture, sports and educational workshops. As the organization founder explains: “The women gain access to opportunities that not only empower them during their time in prison but also provide them with tools and skills that allow them to better themselves and be prepared for the challenges of life as free women” (Organization founder, personal communication, January 15, 2019).

Methodology

Location

All of the information in this study was collected inside three prisons where the participants are deprived of their liberty and where they engage in work with the Organization Studied. The three prisons are located in greater Mexico City, in the state of Mexico. The observations and interviews were conducted on patios, in cafeterias and around work tables in public areas inside the prison, as we were not allowed to interview the participants in private. However, all of the interviews were conducted such that there were as few distractions as possible.

Participants and Sampling Strategy

The total number of participants in the programs of the Organization Studied varies from month to month and even from one week to another because many of the participants enter while others leave. Nevertheless, during the months leading up to the study, the average number of inmates registered in any one of the aforementioned programs was 67 individuals, all women, 19 of whom were being held in the prison that we will call A, 26 in prison B, 15 in prison C, and seven who continued to work with the organization even though they have been released. Our team was able to interview a total of 32 of these participants, ensuring that our sample would represent the proportion of prisons A, B and C mentioned above as well as the ex-inmates (28%, 39%, 22% and 11%, respectively). Similarly, we sought to represent the participants' age groups: 18-24 years: 3 participants; 25-35: 10 participants; 36-45: 13 participants; 46-55: five participants; and 56-65: one participant.

Aside from the criteria of the proportion of prisons and age groups, the participants were chosen randomly. Additionally, we attempted to represent the highest number of workshops and programs implemented by the Organization Studied (several of the women we interviewed participate in more than one workshop simultaneously). From prison A, 11 of the women interviewed participate in the knitting workshop, five in the psychology workshop and one in the human development workshop. From prison B, 14 of the women interviewed participate in the knitting workshop and three in the art psychotherapy workshop. From prison C, five participate in embroidery, 2 in textile weaving, one in “Empowerment for women”, two in yoga, five in meditation, one in a workshop called “Postcards of life”, one in a Mandala workshop, one in a “book club” and one in a personal image workshop.

It is important to note, however, that the only workshops that provide inmates with a source of income are those in which they make products to sell (weaving, embroidery and textile weaving). These are the most highly attended workshops, and a large part of the conversations during the interviews refers to them.

The procedure for contacting and recruiting participants, as well as conducting the study, adhered to Mexican laws regarding the privacy and protection of personal information. Each participant signed an informed consent form before her interview, and the security of the information provided adhered to the ethical standards of the Universidad Iberoamericana.

Data Collection

Data collection consisted of 32 individual in-depth interviews carried out on-site. A semi-structured interview protocol was used, in part taken from the literature review and in part designed to investigate in-depth the categories that we wanted to explore. The questions were varied, and they were explored in-depth by the interviewers to extract as many details as possible regarding the relevant issues addressed by the women interviewed. We were not allowed to bring electronic equipment for recording interviews into the prison. For this reason, we decided to conduct each interview with a team of two people. One person was the interviewer and only took notes relevant to his or her interview. The second person was only engaged in writing, in the fastest and most literal manner possible, each phrase and word emitted by the woman interviewed. Although it was impossible to capture 100% of each conversation, the interviewer pairs met and exchanged data to ensure that the transcription was as true as possible to the interview. Only in the case of four ex-inmates who were interviewed in conditions of freedom could we record the interviews and transcribe them word-for-word in their totality.

Additionally, during each visit, both team members engaged in thorough observation of the outside and inside areas of the prison and of the activities of the inmates, in the hopes of complementing the issues mentioned by the participants. Upon completing each interview, the interviewers wrote notes in two columns. In one of the columns, they explained in detail what they had observed. In the other, they described how they felt during the observation and interview (Janesick, 2004).

Data Analysis

All of the interviews were transcribed as explained above and subsequently processed using the qualitative software *NVivo 12.0*. For the analysis, both pre-existing categories (taken from the literature review and our pilot interviews) and emerging categories were used. With this objective, words, phrases or complete paragraphs were selected, which were then coded within these categories for the purpose of detecting patterns and repetitions as well as the emergence of new topics.

The following table shows the pre-existing categories used.

Table 1.0 Pre-existing categories

A. Factors prior to prison and general topics
Dysfunctional or disintegrated nuclear family

Physical violence
Sexual abuse
Unemployment
Low salaries/economic problems/needs
I did not commit any crime/I am here for unjust reasons
References to issues of structural violence
Conception of well-being as tranquility or emotional peace
Conception of material well-being
B. Psychological, social or psychosocial effects from being in prison
Affected by abandonment by a partner/spouse or man
Fear of recidivism
Physical handicaps (illness, injury)
Emotional distress
Decreased attention
Fear/apprehension regarding what might take place outside of prison/fear of rejection
Symptoms of stress
Lack of motivation
Fear of being in prison
Feelings of aggression on the part of inmates (physical or emotional)
Feelings of aggression on the part of custodians (physical or emotional)
Feelings of injustice due to the conditions in which I live
Unfair/improper treatment by the prison authorities (not custodians)
Affected by some punishment received
I'm bored/there is nothing to do
Subhuman conditions (dehumanizing, below that which is human)
Basic needs (water, food) are not being met
Untrained/poorly prepared custodians
Corruption/the corruption in prison affects me
I am affected by confinement/there is no nature/there is no open space
I am affected by the feeling that I am less of a person because of my prisoner status (here, I am nobody, I am not important)
Not being able to see my children affects me
The conditions I live in are not bad/they are good
I have learned to value things that I did not value before
General lessons learned from being in prison (not from the Programs)
C. Perceived possible improvements due to the Programs
Emotional well-being due to the Programs
Feeling of self-betterment
Better prepared to confront life outside of prison
Development of skills/knowledge
Development of skills for facing life outside of prison
Improves my quality of life inside prison
I use the income for myself
I use the income for my family
I value my ability to earn money

The Programs keep me busy/my mind occupied and keep me out of trouble
The Programs keep me busy (before I would get bored)
Less stress or improvement in stress
Greater motivation
The Programs give me work experience
The Programs improve my coexistence/interaction with other inmates
The Programs improve the environment in the prison
The Programs give me goals/hope
The Programs help my self-esteem/self-confidence/pride
The Programs give me a sense of self-sufficiency (keep me feeling like myself/not needing others)
The Programs make me feel like I am not in prison
The Programs make me feel accomplished
The Programs make me feel responsible (responsibility increases)
The Programs help me feel safe from violence or aggression
The Programs help me support my household/children/family
For me, the programs mean something different/something personal/something of myself (resignification)
Appreciation for listening to them and making their voice heard
D. Gender themes
Feminine subjectivity/feminine identity
Masculinities
Gender condition helps (they do not treat me as badly for being a woman/they treat men worse)
My being here is the direct consequence of a man
My being here is the indirect consequence of a man
E. Problems or areas of opportunity
Problems of time
Problems of coordination (work/material disorganization)
Logistical problems
The Programs do not help me face life outside of prison
The work experience provided by the Programs will not be useful for working outside of prison
The Programs do not help me with my emotional needs
The Programs do not improve my quality of life in prison
The Programs do not develop skills
The Programs do not improve self-esteem/self-confidence
The Programs do not give me hope
The Programs are only remedial/they are not long-term solutions

Some of these themes appeared frequently during the interviews. Others appeared only a few times or not at all. Many more categories emerged during the interviews, as shown in the results section.

Trustworthiness

It is worth noting that this was a very particular study in terms of the emotional impact that it produced in each of the researchers. It would be dishonest to say that we remained entirely “neutral” in our reactions to what we heard, observed and experienced throughout the months that we visited the prisons. For this reason, this study should be read keeping this limitation in mind.

That being said, a considerable effort was made to guarantee the reliability of the results. This included the following elements: (a) a combination of qualitative methodological tools was used that included not only the in-depth interviews but also detailed observations aimed at providing additional objective elements that could be compared with findings; (b) interviews were conducted in teams of two and the notes of the two interviewers were subsequently contrasted to control the bias of one or the other of them; (c) interviews were conducted by seven different researchers, which helped control potential individual biases; (d) note taking included the feelings and impressions of the researchers, who were frequently affected by what they observed during several months of visiting the prisons, which helped control potential biases rooted in cumulative emotions; (e) concurrently, continuous meetings were held, in which the entire team participated to compare information and feelings and to contribute to the control of potential group biases; and (f) contrast tests were performed between the results of the participants from the three prisons where we worked as well as between the age groups and participants of different workshops or programs. The results of all of these contrast tests showed that the major patterns that we detected remained, almost without variation.

Limitations and Transferability

This study offers results that are exclusively related to the 32 inmates or ex-inmates who participate or participated in the Programs of the Organization Studied, whose operations are limited to three prisons in greater Mexico City. While it could be said that the sample is representative of the universe of participants in the Programs of this organization, this same sample does not represent the totality of inmates who participate in similar programs in other prisons or locations. For this reason, these results are not immediately transferable to other projects or similar organizations. However, the repetition of patterns and their consistency with elements detected in the literature, as well as the relevance of themes that stand out the most in the interviews and observations, appear to suggest that this limited case study has much to teach and contribute, not only for application to similar cases but also with regard to the Mexican prison system and peacebuilding in general.

Results

General overview

Given the number of general categories—both pre-existing and emerging—that were frequently mentioned, we separated them into seven subsections to provide a better view. Even so, it is worth noting the most generally recurring themes. The most frequently repeated categories were as follows: *Development of skills/knowledge*, which was mentioned 194 times (f) and mentioned by

100% of the participants at least once. *I value earning money* was mentioned 188 times by 97% of the participants. *Emotional well-being due to the Programs* was mentioned 185 times with 100% of participants mentioning it at least once. *I like the Programs* (f=172; 97% of participants) and *I keep busy or I keep my mind occupied and stay out of trouble* (f=159; 97%) were the next most recurring themes. Other frequently mentioned categories included topics related to their identity or feminine subjectivity (f=131; 91%) and greater motivation due to the Programs (f=125; 91%). Also, of note are references to a negative environment or atmosphere in the prison (f=149; 94%) and the *Lack of their basic needs (water, food, lack of space) being met* (f=112; 84%).

In other words, an overall consideration of the patterns that stood out most during the interviews includes the negative environment in which the participants live, and the lack of basic subsistence needs being satisfied. Nonetheless, in an even more recurring way, the participants tended to elaborate on the benefits that, from their perspective, the Programs offer. Some of these benefits are from the material perspective, such as earning money or even learning new skills, and others are from the emotional perspective, which include a sensation of greater well-being and valuing the ability to keep themselves busy and in this way stay out of trouble in prison, and even topics related to the reinforcement and valuing of their gender identity. Table 2.0 shows an overview of the 10 most recurring categories in the entire study:

Table 2.0 General overview

Categories	Number of coding references	Percentage of participants who mentioned it at least once
Development of skills and knowledge	194	100%
I value earning money	188	96.9%
Emotional well-being due to the Programs	185	100%
I like the Programs	172	96.9%
The Programs keep me busy and help me stay out of trouble	159	96.9%
Negative environment in prison	149	93.8%
Themes related to subjectivity/gender identity	131	90.6%
Greater motivation	125	90.6%
Lack of basic needs	112	84.4%
Unfair or improper treatment by the authorities	98	90.6%

We will now describe the themes most frequently mentioned in each of the following subsections:

A. External (outside of prison) and structural environment

In this subsection, we include all of the references to themes related to the interviewees' life before prison or the references to topics that have to do with structural factors that, according to the perception of the woman interviewed, underlie the crime and violence in her social environment.

The most frequently mentioned category in this subsection, *Reference to issues of structural violence or systemic corruption*, was mentioned 93 times (f) and was noted at least once by 72% of the participants. This means that while there were various references made to the interviewees' lives before going to prison, such as their job (f=80; 97%) or having a family or a social support network that continues to provide care in one way or another to some of the women we interviewed (78%), the better part of our conversations with the inmates revolved around the structural conditions that facilitate violent crime in a country such as Mexico, which, in their experience, includes factors such as inequality, poverty or their dysfunctional nuclear families (f=77; 59%). It is notable that in this section, 69% of the women we interviewed affirmed that they were in prison due to some injustice. According to them, they had not committed any crime and were unduly accused.

Here are some extracts from the interviews that reflect the above topics:

I thought that in 144 hours the lawyer would solve everything. We presented receipts, IRS (Hacienda) documents, proof of my training so they would see that I did not need to do it (the crime), [...] we showed that what the accused was saying was illogical, but the judge decided that there was still probability and that meant that I had to stay [...] Thus I spent months, without information or notifications, and the judge recommended that I plead guilty to a sentence of one year and five months. But why would I accept something I did not do? We went to question the evidence of the accuser because there were many illogical things. They put for example that my vehicle license plates were evidence because I apparently passed near the crime scene. For the judge that was enough. [...] My lawyer recommended that I probably plead guilty, as the judge said. I refuse to plead guilty. (Participant 25).

Your friends end when you go to prison. You have no more friends now. They say that you find out who your true friends are when you are in prison and in the hospital. I don't have friends (Participant 8).

They killed my family. They killed my entire family. It was four years ago. Now I only have my 23-year-old son. He lived somewhere else, with his in-laws, so nothing happened to him. And me, I wasn't in my house when it happened (Participant 12).

Because only those of us who are here know what really happened, we know how the system works. I know what the process is like. I will not plead guilty to the second crime, because I didn't do it, it's police rubbish (Participant 1).

I don't know, but they don't care about us. In this system, the only people they care about are those at the top of the pyramid, not us (Participant 22)

B. The environment inside prison

A total of 94% of the women we interviewed made at least one reference to the *negative environment* that, according to them, exists in prison (see Table 3.0). This category emerged during the interviews with a frequency of 149 repetitions and essentially referred to the *hostility and conflict* that the women experience in their surroundings. The *lack of basic needs*—water, food,

lack of space or minimal conditions for subsistence—was mentioned 112 times by 84% of the participants. In fact, on 94 occasions, 97% of the participants indicated that they live in *subhuman conditions* or below what is humanly acceptable or in *dehumanizing conditions* (for example, similar to how animals are treated). Also notable is the frequency of references to unfair or improper treatment by prison authorities (not custodians but rather prison directors). This category was mentioned on 98 occasions by 91% of the participants. The theme of *emotional distress resulting from being in prison* emerged 95 times among 88% of the participants.

Table 3.0 The environment in prison

Categories	Number of coding references	Percentage of participants who mentioned it at least once
Negative environment	149	93.8%
Lack of basic needs	112	84.4%
Unfair or improper treatment by the authorities	98	90.6%
Emotional distress	95	87.5%
Subhuman conditions (below the minimum requirement for a dignified and human life)	94	96.9%

The following extracts give examples of what was typically mentioned regarding the above or similar categories.

Here the custodians let in cell phones, drugs. The inmate that is best at a task will screw all the others, the one that cooks well, also will screw them all. Sometimes the cooks sell you the same products that the institution gives us to eat (Participant 15). They say that words are weapons, and here, you can see the level of morality by the swear words people use. For example, they say things like “go fuck yourself” or “bitch” [...] At least they respect me because of my size, but I ignore their insults and they get even angrier. They're like little girls. Sometimes they wet my bed so that I can't sleep well or they make it dirty (Participant 23).

The main problem is the food. The meat is rotten or raw, or badly cooked. The rice is uncooked, often hard and going bad. In the other prison, they sold pork chops, onions, cilantro, and so you could cook. And when visitors come, we have to eat the food cold because there aren't even ovens (Participant 14).

Even visiting is hard. Those who come have to pay, for food or whatever. Each person per visit costs \$500 (Participant 23).

The food is really horrible. We don't have water in the cells. There are two faucets that everyone has to use, and sometimes there is no water at all. There are a lot of problems due to water, I think it's because of the over-crowding, there are a lot of us. I would say that the water and drugs are the worst part about being here in prison. Even though I don't use drugs,

if they smoke pot in my cell, I get dizzy. The custodians don't even come up here and they don't see what is happening (Participant 24).

How do they categorize us? Are we citizens? Because in my work (participant is a veterinarian), heads of cattle are supposed to have certain conditions like space, care, sufficient food, etc. Here there isn't any space or water or light or ventilation. How do they categorize us? What are we? With 110 people in only one cell, what are we? A bed is 60 cm x 1.60 m, and two prisoners sleep in each one. Everyone else sleeps on the floor and under the beds, and if they still don't fit, they take up the entire hallway, and imagine what it's like going to the bathroom, and then sometimes there is not even water. I've had an infection for three days, and I asked for medication, medicine I've never had to take before. Since I'm a doctor I took really good care of myself out there. Here, I asked for antibiotics. The nurse gave me Naproxen. There was no doctor. The doctor came much later and told me "there is no medication, I don't know why you called me" [...] Each cube (mosaic) measures 25x25 cm, and they only give you one cubby to put your things in, and they don't care. I say to them, so where do I put it? And they say however you can, that it's not their problem. So, I have to take my things everywhere, I tie them up and carry my can so that I can sit and put my things inside (Participant 25).

Water, sometimes we don't have it. Well, sometimes there isn't any hot water either, both things. Then 3 or 4 days will go by that we can't shower because there isn't any water (Participant 13).

You get used to everything. From being hungry to not having anything to eat, that is the worst... Getting used to the fact that there is no food or getting sick. For example, I have bad allergies. When it's cold, I get really sick from my allergies, and the medical care is not good here (Participant 28).

Communication, the director isn't aware of the internal goings-on. The authorities are corrupt. They cut every program. If she had more to do with how the prison is managed, this wouldn't happen. Donations never make it here; they sell you medicine that was donated, and she doesn't know about this. She doesn't have to come, but she shouldn't have cut herself off from the real people. Since all of the authorities are in collusion with one another, I don't know who to turn to. There should be more follow-up with medical care. I asked for some medication a month ago, and they haven't given it to me. It's a real trial. If there were follow-up, there would be more quality care. I have a right to health care, and it doesn't work. They are constantly cutting off the water (Participant 18).

Loneliness. Well, the thing is, I have always been alone, but even just the word "prison" is really strong, it's really scary (Participant 17).

Very very bad. I was depressed. It's really horrible, and in the beginning, I didn't get out of my bed, I just cried all the time. It's my first time in jail, and I didn't know what to expect. It happened so quickly, how I ended up here. I felt very frustrated. I didn't want to do anything or talk to anyone (Participant 20).

Well, I felt really bad. I have a 17-year-old son who's at a very difficult stage. He doesn't have a father or mother, only my mother and my sister who take care of him. He goes out into the street, got addicted, and from here all I could do was talk to him and talk to him. He dropped out of school. It's for this reason that I felt really low. The meditation teacher told me some very wise things that helped me to feel calmer (Participant 24).

C. *Perceived benefits due to the Programs*

As indicated above, this is the most saturated of all the subsections. From the outset, this factor reflects the value that the women we interviewed assigned to being able to work and participate in the programs (see Table 4.0), highlighting the *Development of skills and knowledge* (f=194; 100% of participants), the valuing of *earning money* (f=188; 97%), and, in particular, the possibility of spending their money on themselves or things that are important to them (f=91; 94%), in addition to the *Emotional well-being that they experience due to the Programs* (f=185; 100%). In particular, three out of every four women indicated that they feel *less stress due to the Programs* (f=82). Additionally, 97% of the participants indicated that *they like the Programs* and that the Programs keep their *minds occupied*, which keeps them out of trouble, or *offer an alternative* that is meaningful (f=159). A total of 91% indicated that they feel more *motivated* due to the Programs (f=125). Other notable findings include categories such as experiencing a *feeling of self-betterment* (f=87; 84%). Eight out of every ten of the women interviewed indicated that they felt the Programs helped them *overcome their situation and not give up* (f=76); 72% of them indicated that the Programs generate a *sense of self-sufficiency* (due to feeling that they can take care of themselves and do not need other people). This was noted on 73 occasions during the interviews. Three out of every four women reported *having goals, hope or security about the future* (f=72) due to the programs. Therefore, it is not surprising that 84% of the women we interviewed mentioned on at least one occasion that they are grateful or satisfied with the team that develops and implements the Programs (f=87).

Table 4.0 *Perceived benefits due to the Programs*

Categories	Number of coding references	Percentage of participants who mentioned it at least once
Development of skills and knowledge	194	100%
I value earning money	188	96.9%
Emotional well-being due to Programs	185	100%
I like the Programs	172	96.9%
The Programs keep me busy and help me stay out of trouble	159	96.9%

The following extracts reflect typical references with regard to this subsection:

It enriches me, it teaches me [...] It's great that someone tells you that you can do things. They teach you to be responsible, you realize that the entire world is not against you, but that you do it to yourself and this makes you feel responsible (Participant 1).

They have helped me to be stronger in everything. They help you to realize that you are self-sufficient. If I learned how to knit, I can do anything that I want (Participant 11).

Learn something new. I didn't know how to embroider. And I know that out there this work pays well, so when I leave, I will have something to do. I also learned how to make little dolls (Participant 15).

I am better. Much better. I want to always be well. It motivates me that they pay me, it motivates me to know that they will pay me (Participant 16).

Day after day I get out of that bed so I can work, to be able to pay a lawyer who will help me get out of here. It motivates me to be able to give them (my family) money from what I earn here so that they can buy things, even if it's just to buy some candy (Participant 17).

Working here so that I don't have to ask them for anything. I don't want to depend upon their help. They have their own problems, and I don't want to be a burden (Participant 19).

It's as if they kill you in life, but here inside (the room where the Programs are implemented) is my only refuge [...] I no longer want to kill myself. With this workshop, I am busy, I focus on other things (Participant 9).

Yes, because I have something to do, I get away from all of this, I go into my bubble of work, and a lot of stress goes away (Participant 10).

You're more focused, it makes you see new qualities, you feel like you have personal accomplishments, you see that you contribute and are part of something. They value your work, and this makes you valuable (Participant 7).

It makes me calm. Knitting and wanting to finish the doll to see how it turns out. It gives me peace (Participant 14).

I feel like I am ready to go out. When I leave, I will work. I have a friend who sells potato chips [...] it might also be an option to work in some potato chip stand. I have security, and if not, I'll sell dolls (Participant 12).

D. Themes related to gender

The category of *masculinities* is generally used for understanding two different aspects. The first is the construction of the conception of men and the way in which a patriarchal and *machista* society affects women (Connell & Messerschmidt, 2005). The second aspect refers to the way in which a context of violence is formed within a social fabric, specifically violence towards women. Masculinities define the agenda for being a man, the structure, and the ways in which a man is expected to act, as well as the way in which institutions function insofar as how individuals learn

this series of constructs (Connell, 1995). The process through which masculinities are formed is practically invisible, and a large part of institutions contribute to their construction: schools, military service and churches. From childhood, these constructs are replicated and teach stereotypes of how a man and a woman should behave (Tong, 1998).

Gender performativity can be explored through the notion that all gender roles are constructs through which individual behavior becomes something that society can accept or defy. These gender performances recreate the social meanings of the feminine or masculine sex. The concept of gender follows certain norms in society through which people perceive the elements of a context of inequality and binary hierarchies such as masculine and feminine (Butler, 1999, p. 43).

Thus, in category D, we group all of the references that we identify as being related to gender condition. Three topics stand out in this subsection. The first of them, *Feminine subjectivity/feminine identity*, refers to each time the participants expressed something related to their gender identity or the recognition of their gender subjectivity. This category had a high frequency, 131 occasions, and nine out of every ten women interviewed mentioned it at least once. The second theme that we coded was that of *Masculinities, her gender role or gender issues in general* (f=86; 78% of participants). Lastly, nine out of every ten women interviewed stated that their gender condition helped them or that they were *not treated as badly* in prison because they were women and that men are treated worse (f=55). As we noted in the methodology section, there were some other categories that we pre-coded for this subsection. However, these categories were not mentioned enough to reach saturation.

The following extracts illustrate subsection D:

It is the first time that I have worked alone on something. It was always with my husband; now I've learned to do it alone. It makes me feel like I am capable of doing and finishing any job that is put in front of me (Participant 14).

What happens is that for the first and second year, your family is with you, but afterwards, they leave you. They even change their cell phone numbers and avoid you. We women are ignored more than men, that's why it is more important for us to make money (Participant 15).

Yes, because women normally behave better, so as a woman prisoner, it has a greater impact on you, and also, I have children (Participant 28).

I am different. You should have seen me when I came to this place... and if you saw me now that I'm out of prison, you'd say: "What happened to you?" People on the outside are surprised when they see me. I was little, like this [makes a gesture with her hands] little. I'm telling you, a housewife with a husband who... who humiliated you, hit you and all of that, and now, an independent woman, very sure of herself. A woman who wants to be both father and mother. Of course, it's not easy, because I have my problems, but I can do it. (Participant 30 – ex-inmate).

Women are better off than men (in prison). Men are beaten, they deny them food, there are deaths, injuries, beatings, and this doesn't happen with women, this doesn't happen to us (Participant 11).

Yes, because they give more priority to men (Participant 17).

Well, yes, if the son and husband are in prison, the family prefers to see them over the woman (Participant 12).

It was a robbery, but with violence, I always did what he told me to do, he manipulated me. So, it happened that he told me that we were going to go collect money from a friend of his, but no, this friend was the one from the robbery (Participant 23).

E. Criticism and areas of opportunity for improvement of the Programs

In the interview protocol that we developed, special attention was paid to exploring critical commentaries, suggestions or possible areas of opportunity that the participants identified with the aim of enriching or improving the Programs. The first thing that should be noted is that the number of overall mentions in this subsection was relatively low compared to other subsections. This indicates that the majority of the women interviewed were highly satisfied with the Programs and did not feel the need to suggest improvements. Even so, the following themes identified in this subsection should be noted. There were 93 occasions in which our participants provided suggestions such as the directors of the program coming more often to have more time with the inmates. It is notable that most of the participants mention a desire to have more workshops that are similar to the knitting, weaving, meditation or yoga workshops. Some suggestions included having literary workshops or similar workshops; 21 of the 32 women interviewed spoke of existing workshops that are not those implemented by the Organization Studied. There were 41 references to logistical problems such as the occasional lack of material or that they are paid too late, and specifically, there were 19 references to a lack of coordination in the Organization Studied.

The following gives examples of references related to this subsection:

Nothing, everything is fine. Well, no, I would offer more workshops (Participant 11).

More workshops. That's the only thing (Participant 18).

I think a reading workshop. I would like a writing workshop, a workshop on verbal and nonverbal expression (Participant 25).

I want them to increase production and not take so long to pay me because they sometimes take a long time [...] right now they still haven't paid me for August, two weeks ago (Participant 28).

I like everything. But I think it would be good that they give us more work. (Participant 14).

F. Relevant themes in interviews with ex-inmates

We decided to dedicate a section to identifying specific categories that emerged from the interviews with ex-inmates who participated in the Programs while in prison and who, now that they are free, keep in touch with or continue to work for the Organization Studied. These four participants form part of our total sample, and therefore, the majority of coded categories are included within the previous subsections. The following themes are coded in addition to the aforementioned categories (see Table 6.0). Notably, the four ex-inmates interviewed stated that they highly value the fact that the Organization Studied *maintained contact and followed up* on the participant once she was released (f=33). Similarly, the four ex-inmates mentioned that they were grateful to the Organization because it marked a fundamental turning-point in their life (f=19). Similarly, the four women highlighted that the Organization provided them with useful tools for coping with life outside of prison (f=19). That being said, it should be noted that three of the four women mentioned on 16 occasions that working with the Organization outside of prison was different than working with it inside prison. All four women indicated that working with the Organization after prison can only be used as extra income because it is not enough to live on. Remarkably, three of the four ex-inmates interviewed mentioned 24 times the difficulties they experienced readapting to life outside of prison and the prevalence of negative feelings such as fear, uncertainty, and frustration due to lack of work, not being accepted or not fitting in. In this sense, we can affirm that, for these women, work with the Organization Studied is highly valued; however, its impact outside of prison is limited. This perhaps represents another area of opportunity for this and other similar organizations.

Table 6.0 Relevant categories in interviews with ex-inmates

Categories	Number of coded references	Participants who mentioned it at least once
They followed up on me once I left prison	33	4
Negative feelings upon leaving	24	3
The salary provided by the organization only as extra income	21	4
The Programs changed my life	19	4
They gave me tools to better cope with life after prison	19	4

Here are some extracts from the interviews with ex-inmates that reflect the aforementioned themes:

Even to this day, being outside, the organization has helped me. Because it is really hard, I swear, it is really hard (Participant 30).

Yes, yes, I come to sign, and I have to let them know about everything. Every move I make, I have to let them know. So, I said to them: "I need an employment letter because I have to send it to the judge." And she, well, the Organization, has never told me no. It has been really good to me (Participant 30).

Well, aside from, well, what I learned, because I'm telling you that I had no idea what it meant to pick up a knitting needle or weave or anything, this... well, I don't know... I

learned a lot of things, aside from the fact that it was good because when I left, they continued giving me work while I was looking... for a job (Participant 32).

Yes, the thing is, it's not a lot of money... it's very little, but it's a reliable income (Participant 29).

I would say to them, like this: "Oh, give us more work, because what we earn isn't enough" like that. And they would say: "Okay, yes, we would like to give you, um, a lot" Right? But... well, sometimes depending upon the requests, it was what they gave us, and we were not only those outside, but also inside and all that (Participant 32).

This world is...really, really stressful. There are people... trust me, I have known people, and I say "known" because everything is extreme when you leave. The street is strange, sleeping in a bed is strange, sitting at a table is strange, your family is strange. So, at least in prison, you know that you shouldn't trust anybody. That is, you should be a good prison mate, but only to a point. You know that there, it's just you, and you should look out for yourself. So, you know that you are alone, and you don't hope [...] People on the outside are... selfish sometimes. They only think of themselves. If they are going to benefit in some way, it's fine. And if not... (Participant 30).

It's scary. Yeah, because before I would see the cops, and it would really scare me. When they (the Organization) said to me that we would meet here at Prison C, I felt *horrible*. I felt like they were going to put me in prison again, and I didn't want to come (Participant 31).

Well, they've been really nice. They listen to you. I like them a lot... More than the knitting, *the way that they talk to us*, and how they can orient you, how they advise you. Without knowing you, or anything (Participant 29).

Look, in these places... there aren't going to be many people like them. And I think that one way of thanking someone is by doing things well. I am very grateful. And believe me that these (the Organization staff) will be people who I won't be able to say no to. Really, I think that if some day if I see the psychologist again, I am going to give her a big hug and cry with her. Really. They are people who are very dear to me, even outside of prison (Participant 30).

It's that... well I... I am REALLY grateful to all of them for everything and the truth is that I really like them a lot, I really started to care about them because they are so lovely in... well, in everything. Right? They worry about just everything. And I think, why do they worry when we are, well... nothing. Right? We are strangers to them. I mean, when you begin working at the Organization, you arrive there, and they don't know who you are. In reality, they don't know if you have good intentions in going to work with them or... because inside a prison, there are all types of people, well, not only inside a prison, we know that here on the outside it's the same. Right? (Participant 31)

G. Memos regarding observations and interviews, commentaries of the interviewers

This subsection is a very special one for the investigating team. On the one hand, it represents our observations from each of our visits to the prisons. On the other hand, it is the place in this paper that we devote to expressing our feelings and emotions, clearly recognizing our subjectivity and the challenge that we confront as social scientists when we try to separate ourselves from our object of study. Each visit to prison brought with it observations on the part of the interviewers, resulting in memos that detailed what was observed before, during and after each interview, as well as a column where the interviewer wrote what he or she had felt throughout the process. The detailed analysis of the notes taken reveals the following (see Table 7.0)

The most repeated category in the memos was that of *Negative feelings* in the interviewers (such as fear, sadness, anger or anxiety) (f=211), but followed by *Positive feelings* in the interviewers in reaction to what they experienced or heard from the women they interviewed (f=141). This naturally reflects a mix of emotions. For one, it was only with great effort that we were able to hold back tears in each interview, and for another, these feelings were interwoven with emotions of satisfaction, joy and motivation due to what the women told us owing to their participation in the Programs. On 79 occasions, the interviewers mentioned having been left with a positive perception of the woman interviewed; on 39 occasions, they mentioned that their impression of the woman interviewed was negative (they did not believe her, or they were scared of her). The notes contain 38 references to issues of structural violence such as the systemic corruption that can be observed inside prisons. Specifically, there were 44 references to having observed conditions in the prisons that were assessed as dehumanizing or subhuman (as was the obvious lack of basic needs being met such as water in the bathrooms). There were 17 references to insufficient or inhuman conditions for children who, in prison, live with their inmate mothers. On 17 occasions, the memos mention sensing a negative or hostile environment in the prison. Other themes that were notable in this subsection include the following: *Untrained or poorly prepared custodians* (f=14), *Unfair treatment on the part of prison authorities* (not the custodians) (f=14), 10 references to having observed the *use of alcohol or drugs in the prison* and 10 references indicating that the group of inmates working in the Programs of the Organization Studied were in a bubble that separated them from the rest of the inmates, a close group that did not make problems with other people. These elements that are observable in the prisons appear to confirm several of the references made by the women interviewed.

Table 7.0 Notes regarding observations and interviews

Categories	Number of coded references
Negative feelings	211
Positive feelings	141
Positive perception of the woman interviewed	79
Negative perception of the woman interviewed	39
References to issues of structural violence	38

Here are some of our notes analyzed in this subsection:

It was strange to come home, to shower with hot water and eat something delicious after learning that they sometimes don't have water, and after smelling their food, I had an idea of what it might taste like (Interviewer).

It made me sad to see the conditions of the zone, and a little afraid (Interviewer).

I felt like I trusted the woman I interviewed, I cried quietly, I could not believe where I was. I didn't want to miss the smallest detail, I wanted EVERYTHING to be in my notebook. YOU CAN SEE THAT SHE LOVES THE ORGANIZATION (Interviewer).

I felt fortunate for my situation. I felt grateful to be there. I felt like I was one more, among women like myself (Interviewer)

The atmosphere in the workshop was pleasant. The room is like a bubble inside the prison (Interviewer).

I loved how when we asked her: What have you lost as a result of being here?, she said, "I haven't lost anything, I have gained something." That really got to me (Interviewer).

Yes, I sense the difference between the environment of those who are in the workshop and those who are not. It's like they're more relaxed (Interviewer).

I found it alarming that a prisoner has to get a pregnancy test from outside the prison: Who did she have sex with? Was it consensual? Why doesn't the institution provide this? Will she abort or what will happen with the baby? (Interviewer).

We sat on the bench, and we immediately began to observe the conditions in the prison at that moment, because it always looks different. This time it was really dirty, there are less people than normal, and I see babies for the first time since we began the study (Interviewer).

In her comments, the member of the Organization's team who is accompanying us states that the best thing about the project is that, for a few moments, the inmates feel like they are not being judged or labelled, they feel like someone believes in them. "The most rebellious", she says, "are the most committed". "There is an inmate who told us that she wants to die because she is going to be freed." She also tells us about the protection afforded to rich inmates through payments and how having money guarantees them privileges (Interviewer).

The interviewee says that she hopes the prison director will receive this information, and my feeling is one of extreme frustration because, the truth is, it is very unlikely that what she is asking for will happen, even though I promise to try (Interviewer).

As she speaks, I conclude that this inmate has the keys to the problem: scarcity leads to disputes. And the inability to implement rules in the distribution of scarce resources (basic resources including everything from water to light or space) generates inequalities. This increases disputes and inequality inside prison. A real microcosm of our societies.

Solutions: End scarcity, along with inequality and privilege. Clear rules, even for those working with the Organization. I detect various holes in the program, precisely in the area of being sensitive to the fact that if there are no rules, disputes will emerge, even among these wonderful participants of their programs. They are lacking integration, group cohesion, how to make one woman care just a little about what happens to another, and how to make the Organization incorporate these ideas (Interviewer).

Listening to her story, I break down. She cries, and I almost cry. I hold on. I empathize, and I think: I am an idiot. A real idiot. A little while ago she loaned me a piece of toilet paper to clean off the water on the bench where we are sitting. And as she speaks of the scarcity of basic things—like toilet paper—I realize that I took a little piece of paper from her that SHE COULD NOT SPARE: I feel like an idiot, but I cannot do anything because I don't want her to feel bad or offended (Interviewer).

Comparison and contrasting of results

Some tests were performed to detect possible variations in the repetition of the categories among the different groups of the women interviewed. This included (a) contrasts between the women interviewed from the three different prisons, (b) contrasts between age groups, and (c) topical contrasts between the inmate and ex-inmate participants.

The most frequently mentioned categories among the contrasted groups are almost identical. However, with regard to the differences, it can be noted that the women interviewed from Prison A, probably due to the conditions in which they find themselves, mention certain categories more frequently such as *Negative environment*, *Lack of basic needs*, *References to disputes or conflicts inside prison* and *Unfair treatment by prison authorities*. These themes do appear among the women interviewed from Prisons B and C, but with relatively less recurrence. However, the positive factors of the Programs and the Organization Studied do tend to appear with similar frequency among the women interviewed from the three prisons. These factors include topics such as the *Development of skills*, *Emotional well-being due to the Programs*, the valuing of *earning money* and gender topics such as *Feminine subjectivity or feminine identity*. The age and number or nature of the Programs in which inmates participate do not appear to cause variations as regards the topics most frequently mentioned by the inmates.

Discussion of results from a gendered peacebuilding perspective

The results reflect a combination of elements that must be organized. First, the women interviewed place a considerable emphasis on structural issues that are not directly linked to their life conditions as inmates, which end up being reflected in their more immediate environment due to their situation of deprivation of liberty. In other words, their social and family context, or the circumstances to which they were subject before entering prison, intertwine with systemic corruption, which, in their view, is one of the primary factors that involves them in the supposed committing of crimes. However, concurrently, these structural factors of Mexican circumstances are also involved in their prison situation, translated into an internal corruption, in the lack of access to basic services and minimal basic subsistence needs (such as water, space or unspoiled food), not to mention the possibility of being reintegrated into their society.

Nonetheless, at the same time, the women we interviewed reflected satisfaction with earning their own money, their improved emotional state, having their daily life occupied productively and being free of the problems that are common in their prison, all of which is only possible due to the Programs in which they participate. Thus, what we have here is a double empowerment: first, there is the rehumanization that occurs as a result of feeling that they are not being judged and are being treated with dignity. Second, there is the empowerment that results from feeling capable of producing their own resources and not depending on a man or their family.

In other words, the results reflect the mix of the tragedy that women live inside the prisons of one of the least peaceful countries in the world and, simultaneously, the power of a noncomplementary behavior which is redignifying and rehumanizing—especially if it includes a gender perspective—embodied in the work of a very small organization that offers them paid work, learning tools and a little compensation for their work. Both are important.

The first—the undignified circumstances of prison life—are important because it is impossible to think about peacebuilding in a country that is as fraught with violence as Mexico in a context such as that described in this study. The interviews exhibit not only the weight of structural violence and gender violence inside and outside of prison but also the lack of adequate conditions for subsistence, the lack of respect for minimal rules of coexistence, and the prevalence of privileges and corruption, which tend to feed back into the cycles of violence that, in theory, should be mitigated in a prison system. However, even so, as we explain above, peace is not limited to the absence of violence. Therefore, what this study reflects does not end with the factors that propitiate or reproduce the aggressive spirals inside prisons.

It is essential to add to this the absence of elements that guarantee that, regardless of the crime committed by the inmates, their prison term results in an active component for peacebuilding for the future. These elements are absent until an organization such as the one we studied is introduced into the prison context. For this reason, understanding the results of the interviews is just as important, if not more important, than the problem itself of the structures that subjugate the prison system.

Being able to feel like dignified, valued, productive and motivated human beings—despite these structures—allows the inmates to transform their sense of well-being and provides them with what we could call internal peace during their experience in prison. Furthermore, the women we interviewed, through their participation in the Programs, become small pillars of social peace in their micro environment. In other words, they live in a context that doubly accuses them (as women and as criminals), stigmatizes them and doubly makes them pay the price for their presumed acts through circumstances that make them feel less than human and affects them emotionally. Therefore, it appears natural that the work of an organization that makes them feel just the opposite is highly valued by them. The combination of both elements, the material (due to the money they earn and how they spend this money) and the emotional, ends up empowering them as women and human beings. As a result, apart from affirming that they feel less driven to become involved in acts of violence, the participants, who are visibly grateful, show themselves to be committed to the Organization Studied and other program participants, thus functioning as factors of social cohesion.

The links between the micro and macro are not minor. Consider this example: One of the women interviewed told us the following: “If somebody bothers me, I hit them. I consider them to be equal to me, for this reason they say ‘*lo que te choca te checa*’ (a smack keeps you in line). The truth is, they really exasperate me. And because of our tempers, we clash a lot. That's why I'd rather be alone, to avoid problems.” This phrase is very revealing in terms of what peace means or, to put it more precisely, what breaks peace. “I'd rather be alone” is the breakdown of any opportunity for social cohesion. The lack of minimal conditions for sustaining existence provokes clashes, and therefore, the participant chooses to separate herself and, in this way, avoid these clashes. This, simply put, implies the loss of hope that these so called “Centers of social re-adaptation” might function as such. Under such conditions, there are no opportunities for a country to build peace; there is no possible reintegration but rather a condemnation to propagate cycles of structural and material violence.

By contrast, the interviews themselves appear to be showing us that within a context of re-dignification, gender empowerment, and gainful employment, prison stays could be turned into valuable time for building peace in a society.

Recommendations for future investigation

As we explain above, this qualitative study is of a limited nature and discusses only the participants interviewed. For this reason and because we detect that, at least in Mexico and Latin America, there is a need for more research on programs similar to those that we studied, a first recommendation is to replicate this case study in other prisons and regions, applying similar interview protocols to document the benefits and possible areas of opportunity of these programs. Similarly, the results of this study could be used to develop one or various quantitative instruments with the aim of applying them to much larger samples of female or male inmates and validating the findings presented above.

General recommendations

Despite the limited nature of this study and recognizing the need to validate the results in broader samples, we consider that, due to the high repetition of certain patterns, the findings presented above allow us to make a number of recommendations:

1. Even considering its extensive strengths, the Organization Studied and other similar organizations should pay special attention to logistical matters that have the potential to produce conflicts among the participants given the environment to which they are subjected, an environment that already presents very negative circumstances in which the participants must struggle to survive. Topics such as the lack of material for their work, the lack of rules or neglectfulness with regard to responsibilities, specifically where and how material should be safeguarded and late payment, may downplay some of the Programs' accomplishments.
2. Based on what we detected in the interviews, adding to the Programs' group integration activities that include all of the participants can increase potential benefits.

3. The women interviewed vehemently request that there be more similar workshops, and while it is understandable that the capacity of a small organization can be extremely limited, perhaps it is possible to conceive of collaborative projects between the public, private and social sectors or group projects among various organizations to expand the benefits reported above.
4. The ex-inmates highlight in the interviews the value of the Organization Studied maintaining contact with them and following up on them. Nonetheless, it is also mentioned that once they leave prison, the resources they receive from the Programs are insufficient. This results in an eventual reduction of communication with the organization and, eventually, a loss of communication altogether. This implies that if the aim is to have a greater impact, associations such as the Organization Studied would need to consider means for greater and higher quality production, increasing their reach and obtaining greater financial viability. To this end, we again suggest that organizations consider projects in collaboration with the private sector, especially with socially responsible companies.
5. The most important recommendation that this study can make to the Mexican government and Mexican society, as well as other societies, is the development and implementation of short-, medium- and long-term policies aimed at incorporating programs similar to the ones studied here, but in a more systematized and far-reaching way. This study offers preliminary evidence regarding their effectiveness as instruments for building peace from its roots. Eventually, a prison system that uses similar tools could transform itself from being a factor that contributes to the reproduction of violence to one that aids in building a more peaceful society.

Conclusions

Despite its limited nature, this study offers preliminary evidence that allows us to understand how the precarious life conditions in Mexican prisons are tied to other topics related to the absence of structural peace in the country and the reinforcement of cycles of violence that, in theory, should be broken. Furthermore, the study shows that a fundamental part of the absence of structural peace has to do with a gender perspective that, if understood and addressed, has the potential not only to stop the aforementioned cycles of violence but also to contribute to building positive peace in a small environment. The interviews in this study, in fact, show the dark side of life in prison. However, at the same time, they show the enormous potential of a project implemented on a small-scale that offers skill development, work and pay to women deprived of their freedom in prisons, which are used as tools for re-dignification, human empowerment and, particularly, gender empowerment, emotional well-being, motivation and hope. Such projects allow the participants to turn their prison experience into a catalyst for greater and better social cohesion, which are fundamental pillars of positive peace (IEP, 2018).

Simply put, the organization that we studied is a bit like learning how to knit. But not dolls of yarn but learning to weave the threads that have been broken, the threads of the social fabric that has been damaged. Consider for a moment a prison system that reproduces this type of program on a larger scale, not in the hands of a small organization that struggles daily against the current in an attempt to get ahead, but rather in a systematic way. Imagine that even when serious crimes have

been committed, the national prison system were to react with noncomplementary behavior and offer opportunities instead of rotten food, a lack of medicine, and the absence of space and basic services. This small case study offers evidence showing that the impact of such policies for Mexico, a country that for too many years has been placed among the 25 least peaceful countries in the world, could be surprising.

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